THE JAPANESE ADVANCE

The Pacific War began with Japan's invasion of China and Manchuria in 1937–39 before moving into a second more intensive phase after Japan's attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941. This was followed by the invasion of the Philippines, Burma, Malaya, and the Dutch East Indies (Indonesia) and the seizure of their economic resources.

KEY

- Under Japanese control Dec 1941
- Under Japanese control Jun 1942
- Japanese invasion/landing
- Route of Pearl Harbor carrier fleet
- Doolittle Raid on Tokyo Apr 18, 1942
- Japanese victory
- US/Allied victory
- Inconclusive battle
- Japanese bombing raid
- US/Allied bombing raid





Submarine binoculars
A pair of Japanese conning tower binoculars. Despite the vulnerable Allied supply line in the Pacific, Japanese submarines generally focused on sinking warships rather than merchant vessels.

better at night-fighting and had more effective torpedoes. At the end of 1942, the Imperial Japanese Navy was still holding its own, but against the huge industrial potential of the United States Japan's long-term prospects looked more grim.

INDUSTRIAL MIGHT

The United States embarked on the largest shipbuilding program in history. From 1943 onward the US Navy expanded its resources in the Pacific until it had achieved an overwhelming superiority over the Japanese. New heavy carriers, light carriers, and escort "jeep" carriers were organized into Carrier Task Forces, each with a protective screen of escort vessels. They soon surpassed their target of 27,500 naval aircraft to equip the new carriers. Landing craft were produced on a massive scale for assaults on the Pacific islands, for which the big guns of their ships, plus carrier aircraft, provided fire support. Meanwhile US submarines overcame problems with non-functioning torpedoes to take a mounting toll on Japanese merchant shipping and warships. The US Navy handled its rapid expansion remarkably well, achieving a high level of training for fresh pilots and sailors and the provision of an efficient supply line to keep the massive new fleets at sea. New tactics were developed, turning amphibious landings into precisely coordinated operations, and evolving robust systems of fleet defense against air attack such as the use of destroyer "pickets" to identify incoming enemy aircraft and the coordination of ship anti-aircraft fire with air combat patrols.

Acutely aware of their growing material inferiority, the Japanese fell back upon their fighting spirit. Naval commanders remained committed to seeking a decisive fleet encounter in which they would destroy the enemy against all the odds. The result in 1944 was a series of epic battles as the Japanese Imperial Navy attacked US ships supporting landings on the Marianas and the Philippines. The absolute superiority of US naval aviation, with improved aircraft and better-trained pilots, achieved the destruction of Japanese carrier-borne air power at the battle of the Philippine Sea. At Leyte Gulf the Japanese fleet made its last serious bid for a decisive victory and lost.

DESPERATE OFFENSIVES

Japan's adoption of kamikaze suicide tactics in the final phase of the war was in part a practical response to the problem of how to inflict damage on the well-defended US fleet. What the Japanese really needed was guided missiles, but a suicide pilot could perform a similar function. For the final battles, as the war approached Japan itself, the Japanese had no usable warships and no time or fuel to train naval pilots operating from land bases. A vast fleet of US, British, and Australian ships was the object of mass suicide attacks by pilots who could barely fly. The kamikazes inflicted much damage, but by this stage the Allies could replace ships faster than they lost them. By the end of the war Japan was under total naval blockade. In September 1945 Japan's formal surrender took place on board USS *Missouri* in Tokyo Bay.

1884–1943

ISORUKU YAMAMOTO

COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF OF JAPANESE COMBINED FLEET

Born Isoroku Takana, the future admiral entered the Etajima Naval Academy aged 16 and fought as an ensign at the battle of Tsushima in 1904, losing two fingers on his left hand. He became part of the Yamamoto samurai family by adoption in 1914. As an admiral in the 1930s he was an advocate of naval air power, deploring Japan's obsession with outsize battleships. He was deeply pessimistic about Japanese chances of success in a war against the US, and he opposed Japan's alignment with Nazi Germany. On being appointed commander-in-chief of the Japanese Combined Fleet in 1939, he pushed through the plan for a preemptive attack on Pearl Harbor. On April 18,1943, pinpointed by American intelligence, the aircraft in which he was traveling was shot down over Bougainville.

